

Hanoi prepared for the much greater supply needs that were anticipated. It built a pipeline to pump oil to the South, and supplemented the existing road net with a new Secret Road that connected Tchepone in Laos with the Cambodia-Laos-Vietnam “triborder” region. Able to carry trucks and built entirely under jungle canopy, it could be used 24 hours a day, and accelerated the movement of troops (who had previously marched), reducing deaths and sickness. A mock-up of a US or ARVN-style base camp of regimental size was also built at Bach Mai, outside Hanoi, so that the NVA could practice assaults.

North Vietnam’s military planners also refined the offensive concept. Corps-level commands were set up to lead multidivision forces of combat troops throughout South Vietnam—a capability that Hanoi’s forces had previously managed only in the vicinity of the DMZ. The combat divisions themselves—tasked with mastering the mass tactics in a very short time—each specialized in particular types of attack, such as urban or mountain fighting, or ambushes.

2,000 The number of trucks sent to Hanoi by China between 1971 and 1972, increasing capacity along the Ho Chi Minh Trail by 50 percent.



Keeping up the fight

This Viet Cong propaganda poster, published in 1972, was designed to keep up morale among the guerrilla force during the lull in combat leading up to the Spring Offensive.

Placing the troops

The ambitious plans called for forces of several divisions to attack across the DMZ, in the Central Highlands, and north of Saigon. Priority was initially given to the Saigon area but this shifted to the northern provinces of Quang Tri and Thua Thien shortly before the